THE SEEDS OF A REVOLUTION

Horticulture, raised in a third of our cultivable area, already surpasses foodgrains in production. Now it strives to be the game-changer in agri exports

By **Amarnath K. Menon**

India ranks second globally, after China, in horticulture production now, but still has phenomenal potential to grow as the fresh fruits and vegetable basket for the world. In 2023-24, the country produced 112.6 million tonnes (MT) of fruits and 205 MT of vegetables. We already lead in the production of banana, mango and papaya among fruits, and onion, ginger and okra among vegetables. The problem is in exports. In 2023-24, we exported fresh fruits and vegetables worth $1.8 billion (Rs 15,039 crore), and processed fruits and vegetables (including pulses) worth $2.5 billion (Rs 20,623 crore), says the Agricultural & Processed Food Products Export Development Authority (APEDA). But India's share in the global horticulture produce market is still a measly 1.1 per cent. Initiatives to create state-of-the-art cold chain infrastructure and quality assurance measures are on, but there is still a long way to go. "Farmers play an essential role in our lives, but their needs are not a priority. They do not have an export market for produce and have been reduced to mere vote banks," says P. Chengal Reddy, farm reforms campaigner and secretary-general, Confederation of Indian Farmers Associations, emphasising that horticulture exports can be a catalyst in transforming lives.

Horticulture is already a significant player in agricultural growth, contributing 30.4 per cent to the agriculture gross domestic product (GDP) while using only 13.1 per cent of the gross cropped area. It also contributes about 33 per cent to the agriculture GVA (gross value added), making a significant contribution to the Indian economy. Indeed, if the area under horticulture cultivation goes up by 50 per cent, it could by itself deliver on the long-promised 'doubling of farmers' incomes'. India has also emerged as the fifth largest country in terms of organic agricultural area—2.3 million acres—and is also home to the world's largest number of organic farmers. By 2026, the overall organic farming industry is anticipated to be worth $10.1 billion (Rs 84,797 lakh crore), according to agriculture ministry estimates.

UNTAPPED POTENTIAL

Apart from the large investments by the private sector in horticulture, APEDA has set up several facilities for perishable cargo and integrated post-harvest handling. Capacity-building initiatives at the farmer, processor and exporter levels are also taking place. A big advantage for India is its unique eight agro climatic zones, which ensure the availability of a wide variety of fruits and vegetables throughout the year. In 2023-24, fruit cultivation was taking on 7 million hectares, while vegetables were being harvested on 11 mha. Horticulture surpassed foodgrains in production per hectare in 2011-12 and stood at 12.5 tonnes per hectare in 2021-22 as against 2.2 tonnes for foodgrains. Not only this, horticulture creates higher incomes for farmers and more job opportunities for farm labour in rural areas (a hectare of fruit production generates 860 man-days of work a year as against 143 man-days with cereal crops).

Export growth in the horticulture sector is undermined by production and marketing challenges, inadequate transport infrastructure, fragmented supply chains and insufficient storage facilities. So becoming globally competitive is one of India's biggest challenges. Domestically, horticulture's penetration and spread are steadily rising. Small and marginal farmers (those with less than 2 hectares), who account for 86.2 per cent of those involved in horticulture, have taken to it in many areas as there is high demand for their produce. Rising incomes, urbanisation and the apparently contradictory trends of improved health awareness and higher consumption have all been contributing factors. A number of government initiatives like agri export zones and GrapeNet have also helped in horticulture's growth.

But small operational holdings are also among the many

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